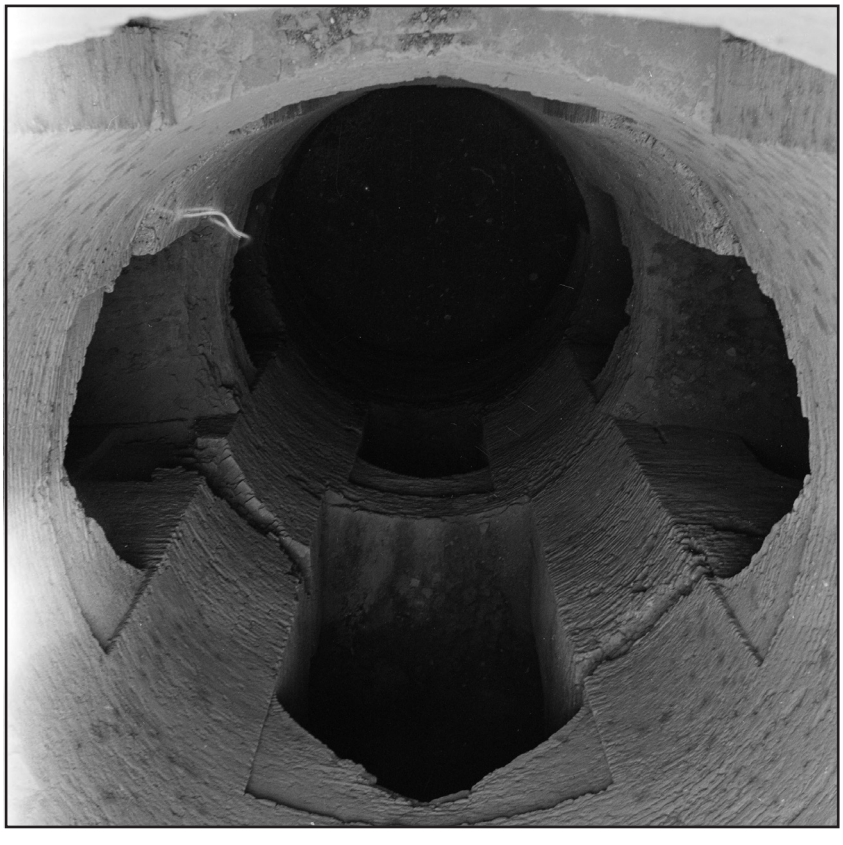


Figure 5.11 *Bust, citadel, ruins, interior, seven-story well: man stands among upper floor arches. © Photograph Josephine Powell c. 1960. Harvard Fine Arts Library, Special Collections.*

The oft-illustrated, distinctive monumental arch inside the lower enclave of Bust (Figures 5.9, 5.12 and 5.13] would appear to be one of the few, new Shansabani foundations at Bust, perhaps along with the galleried well just discussed. The arch would certainly qualify as a project of imperial proportions, though its context and ultimately the impetus behind it both remain mysterious.[34] The arch's interpretation as a monumental entrance addorsed to a large mosque or other complex was refuted early on by the fact that elaborate stucco decoration graced its eastern and western surfaces, indicating its viewability from both sides (Figures 5.12 and 5.13).[35] Its more elaborately decorated eastern face carried Q. II: 127,[36] and, depending on the calligraphic spacing, possibly other verses as well. This part of Surat al-Baqara describes Abraham

> … raising the foundations of the House and Ismael [saying], "Our Lord, accept this from us. Indeed You are the Hearing, the Knowing."